



Looking for New Allies

KOLKATA With the high drama of Singur and Nandigram over, Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee is back to her strategising self. This time she's determined not to repeat her mistakes of last year's assembly elections where her alliance with NDA had cost her the 'mahajot' (grand alliance) with non-Left parties.

Banerjee, for all practical purposes, is now out of the BJP-led NDA and into a pact with the Congress in

West Bengal. Last week she almost announced that the Trinamool-BJP alliance was over. This week, she met Prime Minister Manmohan Singh to work out a pact with the Congress anticipating mid-term Lok Sabha elections.

Sources say not only has the Congress in the state agreed to join the Trinamool if elections take place, they have also promised to carry on the alliance and fight the next Assembly polls together in four years' time. If the

LONG LOST: Banerjee (right) with Singh

joint efforts bear fruit, one might even see Banerjee vying for the chief minister's chair, although that would first involve defeating a three-decade-old Left monopoly.

It is no secret that the Trinamool and BJP relationship had hit rough waters during last year's state polls. Banerjee was trying to form a united anti-Left front. She had had partial success with the late Ghani Khan Chowdhury promising to support her in Malda, but the rest of the state Congress was adamant that she dump BJP and shake hands with them. At that time, she could not leave an alliance that she was one of the key members of.

But this time she is taking no chances. BJP couldn't secure a seat in the last general elections, and continuing to support them will be a losing proposition. So, Banerjee is looking out for new friends and it seems she's found them. **by Swagata Sen**

Retail Therapy

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The large retail sector in Kerala, facing a Marxist onslaught, has found some unexpected friends. The Consumer Protection Council held rallies and campaigns in north Kerala to welcome large chains like Reliance, saying it is the best way to bring down prices and end the local traders'



A Reliance Retail store

monopoly. A new convert to their cause is former Justice V.R. Krishna Iyer, the socialist icon and campaigner against capitalism. He's written to Reliance Retail's state chief welcoming them if they don't monopolise the market, will encourage organic farming and bring consumers and farmers into direct contact.

by M. G. Radhakrishnan

OBJECT OF DESIRE

Time Flame

OMEGA SEAMASTER PLANET OCEAN CHRONOGRAPH, Rs 34 lakh

Retaining most of the original diver's watch functions, the 'Orange Mécannique' has a white gold dial overlaid with black mother of pearl that stands out sharply against the orange alligator strap. Baguette cut diamonds mark the hours in orange Arabic numerals. The hour and minute hands are visible even in pitch dark, thanks to the super lumina coating. A self-winding mechanical movement ensures accuracy with a power reserve of 52 hours. Water-resistant to an astounding 2,000 feet. Adorn your wrist in excellence.



Hawkers Drive

MUMBAI Pune-based Maharashtra Pathari-Hathgadi Vyavasayik Sena, a hawkers union, protested against the city's MPs and MLAs who failed to come to their rescue when the corporation launched an anti-hawking drive. In the Bheek Mango Andolan, the Sena held protest rallies with 40,000 hawkers outside the residences of the elected representatives. The Sena wants the hawkers to be rehabilitated and given alternative space to carry out their business.

by Renu Ojha